

CDN Incident Alert: 0043. TLP: CLEAR			Date	Breakout Scale
Title	DE	Coordinated and verified – pro-Kremlin campaign published hundreds of posts on X	31/01/2025	1

Summary

- CeMAS documented a Pro-Kremlin network of inauthentic accounts on X involved in an influence campaign targeting German audiences. The campaign had been previously documented by Reset Tech in July 2024, but is still ongoing.
- Ahead of the Federal election, the campaign was promoting the far-right party AfD and the left-wing BSW alongside spreading pro-Kremlin narratives about the full-scale invasion of Ukraine.
- The network used verified X accounts and hijacking of trending hashtags to increase the visibility of its posts. The campaign displays clear characteristics of coordinated inauthentic behaviour (CIB) thus violating X's policies on CIB.
- The impact of the campaign is likely to be limited. However, the fact that it is still active on the platform after public exposure in July 2024 indicates insufficient efforts by X to proactively identify CIB and suspend accounts violating its policies.
- The influence operation is trying to create division in German society and degrade Ukraine by flooding the information space to spread existing narratives using existing hashtags.
- X should increase its efforts to pro-actively identify CIB and prevent malicious actors from using verified accounts.

Incident

CeMAS documented effort by inauthentic pro-Kremlin accounts on X to target German audiences. The campaign is a continuation of the multilingual pro-Kremlin influence operation on X, which was first documented by Reset Tech (1; 2) in July 2024. Based on the posting pattern described by Reset Tech, CeMAS was able to uncover a total of 563 German-language pro-Kremlin posts originating from 18 accounts for the period from December 20, 2024 to January 21, 2025. The posts typically included several sentences and a combination of trending hashtags, as well as either a video (372) or a quote tile (191) on current topics with pro-Kremlin framing. Similar text modules, images and videos were used across multiple accounts. Of 18 accounts, 15 had the X verification checkmark, meaning that more favourable distribution conditions can be assumed for their 449 posts.

Narrative

Portraying sanctions against Russia as ineffective and harmful to the West; portraying Ukraine as inferior or defeated; portraying Russia as superior; advocating for peace negotiations with Russia; portraying Russia as a country of traditional values; stoking war fears; supporting AfD and BSW parties ahead of the Federal elections; portraying support for Ukraine as harmful to German economy; claims that sympathy with Russia is growing worldwide; portraying support for Ukraine as escalation; claims about global alliance of right-wing politicians; pushing for negotiations without involvement of Ukraine.

Impact

Reach: By January 22, 2025, the 563 posts had achieved a total of 191,681 views.
Outcome: The real-life impact is likely to be limited.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

- T0079: Divide - The campaign amplified polarising narratives;
- T0066: Degrade Adversary – The Campaign attempted to diminish support for Ukraine in Germany and promote parties known for their pro-Kremlin positions ahead of the elections;
- T0003: Leverage Existing Narratives – The campaign used narratives aligning with BSW and AfD;
- T0049: Flood Information Space – The campaign is consistently posting content to X.
- T0015.001: Use Existing Hashtag – The campaign reaches it's target audience by using hashtags.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Reported to X, the European Commission and German authorities
Recommendations: X should increase its efforts to pro-actively identify CIB and prevent malicious actors from using verified accounts

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
Link	Ukraine, German election.	Evidence archived by CeMAS, available on request.	Lea Fruehwirth, CeMAS	X	